

silence finally ends and the discussion begins, everyone in the room has a deeper, yet shared, understanding of what the agenda is.

The logic of the 'empty chair' in the room

Along with the focus on switching up the way meetings are conducted, Bezos also changed the way the senior management looks at the business. Rather than blindly trying to chase profits, he wanted the team to understand why they're working. Safe to say, Bezos had an obsession with the customer.

In the early days of Amazon, he was famous for keeping one chair empty in every conference room, and he told his staff that the chair was occupied by the most important person in the company, the customer. Interestingly, the obsession over the customer experience didn't just stop there.

Before a single line of code was written for a new product, Bezos wanted the team to write an internal press release. In the release, he wanted the team to imagine it as a launch day and describe exactly how the product will change the customer's life.

If the press release doesn't sound revolutionary to the team, then the project was altogether scrapped. By obsessing over the customer's experience so much, Amazon really ensured that it never built an app or a solution that was in search of a problem.

How it helped Amazon shape their future

Eventually, this is the analogy that took Amazon to the next level. Look at Amazon Prime, for example; while on paper, the unlimited shipping service for an annual fee looks like a financial liability, it still worked out for Amazon. If the idea had been proposed on the traditional PowerPoint logic, it would have been dismissed completely.

Since it would have showcased how the company would lose money on every package. But rather than that,

the company switched the narrative, as Prime was targeted at the long-term psychology of the customer, and that's how it worked out in the end.

Something similar went down with Amazon Web Services, aka AWS. At the start, it didn't start as a plan to dominate the internet's infrastructure. Rather, it was started as an internal memo about how to make Amazon's own developers more efficient. But

flopped and how heavily it was criticised. But at the same time, Amazon realised that the concept showed a lot of potential. While the voice-recognition system was not the best that was available in the market, it was still a starting point for them.

It helped set up the stepping stone from a project that we today know as the Echo. Learning from the mistakes of the Fire Phone is what mas-



because the narrative for AWS was so logically sound, it scaled from an internal tool to a multi-billion-dollar industry leader.

Freedom to fearlessly experiment

While the ban on PowerPoint may have sounded a bit too extreme at first, it also helped foster a unique approach to failure. In many companies, a failed project is often seen as something that would end up getting you fired. But Amazon really changed that narrative. Even if a project failed, it wasn't seen as a complete failure; rather, if the idea behind it was good enough, it was viewed as a good experiment.

One of the best examples of this is the infamous failure of the Amazon Fire Phone. While many might remember how badly the product

sively helped with the success of the Amazon Echo, which we know today.

Power of the written word

Today, Amazon is one of the most complex yet fast-moving organisations. They're present all across the globe, yet they still operate on the simple act of writing. By banning the usage of PowerPoint and focusing more on writing, Jeff Bezos ensured that Amazon would value ideas.

In today's fast-moving world, thanks to the age of artificial intelligence, Jeff Bezos' idea of the six-page memo makes a piece of paper still something that dominates the senior corporate level at Amazon. **d**

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